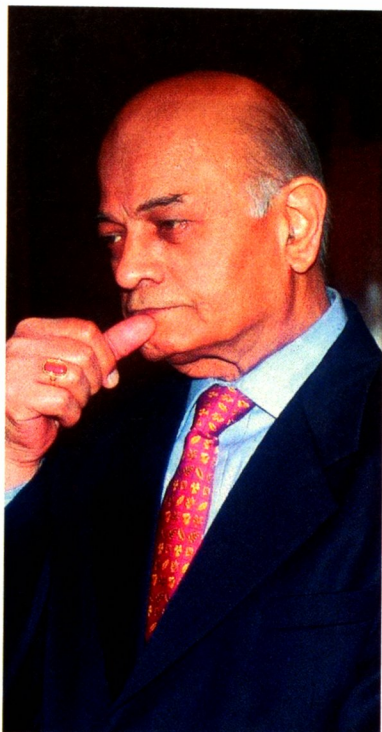




SIPRA DAS



PTI PHOTO

UNEASY BILATERALS: (Clockwise from left) Rajnath, Mulford, Mishra and Advani with Kissinger

shifted from asking for a Joint Parliamentary Committee on the deal and demanding 'renegotiations' to getting reassurances on maintaining India's credible nuclear deterrence and independent foreign policy.

Interestingly, Rajnath told Mulford that he blamed both Indian and US governments for making this deal the focal point of the Indo-US relations. "Both governments have made this the one issue that can make or mar our relations," he said. The American view tends to see the Indian nuclear fiasco as a failure in marketing rather than a negotiating one. The callers from the West have told various BJP leaders that while the Bush administration had lobbied and met individually each and every Congressman who opposed the deal and tried to convince them, this kind of effort was clearly missing in India. "The Indian Government should have positioned this as a deal that gives India freedom from global sanctions rather than marketing it as an Indo-US deal," agrees Robinder Sachdev, co-founder of the US-India Political Action



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